

PHP tools is a good free IDE for PHP development. If you want a very professional tool, there is probably no IDE which can beat PhpStorm. However PhpStorm is a paid product which is available to students, lecturers and open source contributors for free – all you have to do is apply for a free license at JetBrains.com.

In the course of learning any language, one of the most important resources is the API documentation of that language. If you are keen to learn PHP, you are lucky – PHP has one of the most useful, easy and detailed API documentations with examples, warnings, best practices guide along with user comments for almost every function in the language (and many other popular extensions).

strcmp
(PHP 4, PHP 5) strcmp — Binary safe string comparison
Description
<pre>int strcmp (string \$str1 , string \$str2)</pre>
Note that this comparison is case sensitive.
Parameters
str1 The first string.
str2 The second string.
Return Values
Returns < 0 if str1 is less than str2; > 0 if str1 is greater than str2, and 0 if they are equal.
Examples

PHP's API is thoroughly documented

The popularity also means that you can search for your problems on the web and would usually get a good answer written already. If not, StackOverflow.com is a great place to ask questions. If reading books and understanding the underlying architecture is your style, Programming PHP, by Rasmus Lerdorf (creator of PHP) himself would be the best you can get for the language.

When you go for PHP development, unlike most other programming languages (except Java, probably), you will be exposed to an overwhelming number of frameworks. Remember to read about MVC (Model View Controller) architecture and how it works because moving forward, that might help you a lot. 